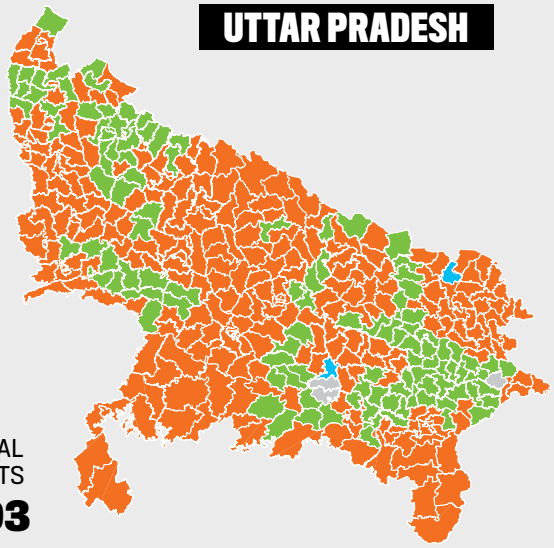
Few would claim to know Modi's mind or how it works. But the prime minister is said to arrive at decisions only after considering the feedback from key party colleagues and his own assessment of a situation. While Yogi had his shortcomings, he had also run UP with an iron hand, cracking down on big mafia gangs that earlier operated with impunity. This even earned him the moniker of 'Bulldozer Baba'. That many members of these gangs were Muslims cemented Yogi's image as a hardline Hindutva icon, one that he had assiduously projected. It included his strident campaign against so-called 'love jihad' or interfaith relationships. More importantly for Modi, Yogi had successfully implemented the score of welfare measures the PM had launched. Particularly the free rations scheme, which provided every card holder not just grains but pulses and cooking oil too to tide over the pandemic. With the 2024 election just two years away, a decisive win in Uttar Pradesh was critical for Modi and the BJP to bolster its chances for re-election.

And UP, which sends 80 legislators to the Lok Sabha, was a much coveted trophy. With his ascetic charisma and a firm style of governance, Yogi had helped the BJP repeat its sweep of the state in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, though with a slightly smaller tally than it had managed in 2014. He had a certain X factor too. Modi saw in him a kindred spirit, one who, like him, had devoted his life to a cause, had no *parivar* (family) to promote and was incorruptible in the public eye.

Last November then, on a visit to Lucknow to address a state police conference, Modi summoned Yogi to the state governor's residence where he was staying. There, in a carefully choreographed sequence, Modi was photographed strolling with Yogi, a paternal arm around his shoulder, apparently discussing matters of state. Then they posed together with Modi raising Yogi's hand in a manifest show of support. Soon after, the Prime Minister's Office reportedly told Yogi to tweet the photographs with the words, "We have embarked on a journey. We have dedicated everything and pledged to build a new India which will touch the heights beyond the sky with new light." In enacting this public endorsement, the prime minister sent out a categorical signal to the party that Yogi will not be replaced and that the chief minister and he will be the faces of the "double-engine sarkar" campaign for the UP assembly election. On the stumps, too, Modi on many occasions showered liberal praise on Yogi's governance, with some partymen saying it was more than what he said about other BJP chief ministers.

BJP STRIKE RATE

UTTAR PRADESH

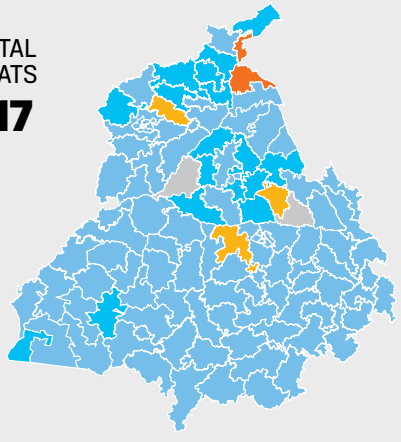


TOTAL SEATS **403**

	BJP+	SP+	CONG.	OTHERS
SEATS WON	273	125	2	3
VOTE SHARE	44%	36%	2%	18%

PUNJAB

TOTAL SEATS **117**



	AAP	CONG.	SAD	BJP	OTHERS
	92	18	3	2	2
	42%	23%	18%	7%	10%

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY & ASIT ROY